

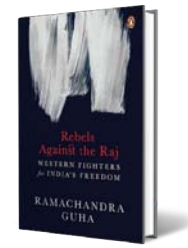
B

Benjamin Guy Horniman came to Calcutta in 1904. Unlike his colleagues at *The Statesman*—British journalists who went to the races in the afternoon and the Bengal Club after—Horniman preferred keeping his nose to the grindstone. He travelled widely. He wrote about rural suffering and Hindu-Muslim strife. Protesting the partition of Bengal, he walked barefoot on Calcutta's streets, 'dressed in a white *dhoti, kurta* and *chadder* like an Indian patriot'. In 1919, when he was editor of the *Bombay Chronicle*, he again stood out. As Mahatma Gandhi arrived at Chowpatty to protest the Rowlatt Bills, only 'one Englishman' was seen in the big, bustling crowd—Horniman.

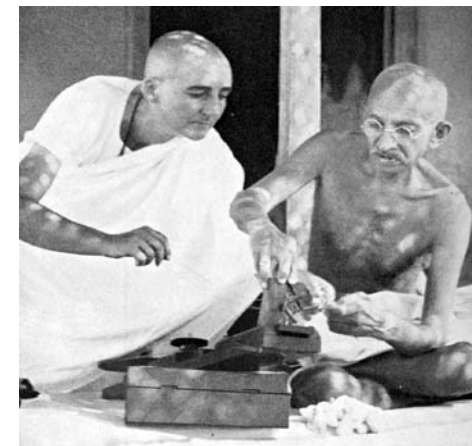
Reading Ramachandra Guha's *Rebels Against the Raj*, it becomes clear that Horniman was more catalyst than he was exception. Deported for 'openly, explicitly, identifying with the nationalists against the Raj', the campaign for his return to India finally came to be championed by the likes of H.G. Wells and George Bernard Shaw. "But he was still kept out for seven years," says Guha, speaking to us over Zoom. Horniman's dissent, Guha feels, interrupts the colonial narrative of supremacy: "We must remember there were only 200,000 British people ruling this large, diverse and densely populated country. Because they were so few, they needed to be convinced they were innately superior to brown people—not just economically, technologically or politically but morally, ethically, and culturally, too."

In *Rebels...*, Guha adds Horniman to his cast of seven foreign freedom fighters—four British, two American, one Irish. Though they are dissimilar in several, obvious ways, they do also have a few things in common: they are all white-skinned, they are all upstanding, and they all 'saw in another nation the possibility of pursuing social and political ideals that make human life more appealing everywhere'. The majority of their stories are unknown, but as Guha makes evident, their courage was also unlikely.

Daughter of a British naval officer, Madeleine Slade, for instance, was only 31 when she first heard of Gandhi in 1924. Her immersion in his philosophy was soon near-complete. By the time she arrived at Sabarmati in 1925, she had adopted vegetarianism and learnt how to sit cross-legged for long hours. While Slade called Gandhi 'Bapu', he adopted her and called her 'Mira'. Even though Mira was initially tasked with looking after Gandhi's spinning wheel, her participation in India's freedom struggle was more than just symbolic. Her activism worried the British enough to have her jailed.



REBELS AGAINST THE RAJ
Western fighters for India's freedom
by Ramachandra Guha
PENGUIN
₹799; 496 pages



As it happens, all seven of Guha's renegades were either imprisoned, detained or deported at some point or another. "I think it shows the depth of one's commitment," says Guha. "Also, I didn't want to just write a book about foreigners who became Indians—that would have to include many mystics, teachers, doctors, social workers—so I used one defining condition: jail or deportation."

Philip Spratt, we see, writes the most delightful letters to his Tamil lover from inside prison. There is zeal in the Communist's writing, but also a warm tenderness. In some of the other letters that Guha has found in his research—especially those that foreign freedom fighters wrote to Gandhi—we find a respect that often stops short of veneration, leaving room for disagreement. In November 1924, American social worker Samuel Stokes wrote Gandhi a letter, openly opposing the Mahatma's desire to make spinning mandatory for all Congress members. A critic of his satyagraha movement, Annie Besant once told Gandhi in a trenchant missive, 'You little realise how you have led young men

ALL SEVEN OF RAMACHANDRA GUHA'S RENEGADES WERE EITHER IMPRISONED, DETAINED OR DEPORTED AT SOME POINT OR ANOTHER